In any case the youth of today have hardly known the kind of military rule that their parents lived under. The 'democratic decade' with alternating rules of Benazir Bhutto and Nawaz Sharif started in 1988. Musharraf's military rule was rather different than that of his military predecessors with his emphasis on 'Enlightened Moderation' quite a stark contrast to the last military dictator, Zia-ul-Haq, and his Islamization policy. Musharraf ensured that elections were held in 2002. So the understanding of Pakistan's youth is that of a country mostly led by democratically elected rulers and one pseudo despot.[8] Democratic rule, more than any other form of government, is what has shaped their view of state–citizen relations. Although they have grown up under more 'democratic governance', the young people of today have experienced less state responsibility towards citizens than previously. Consequently, there is a malaise across the youth; they have little or no understanding of the functions or 'use' of the state. Young people feel disconnected because the state is absent. While issues such as the energy crises and unemployment have triggered sporadic protests in urban centres, with calls for the state to take responsibility for the provision of basic amenities, the response of the state has been negligible. State responsibility only exists on paper, as families have to fend for themselves and rights, especially related to social goods, are largely nonexistent. Life across all sections of society is lived in parallel to the state structures. The state makes an occasional appearance, for example after natural disasters such as the floods in Sindh in 2010 and 2011, when limited aid was provided to certain communities (Siddiqi 2014); however, civil society also carries a large part of post-disaster burdens. Right-wing religious organizations are also known to intervene in post-disaster relief efforts, thereby gaining on the ground support (Bano 2009). Often the military is perceived as the only visible part of the state, from anti-terror operations to providing relief camps. With regard to rights, it seems to make little difference to ordinary people what kind of government is in power – military or democratically elected.[9]

Given this reality one can argue that there has been a historical failure by the political elites to make the state relevant to the wider population. Only now in 2018 has there been an acknowledgement of this failure albeit through a counterextremism strategy. The NCEPG 2018 clearly state:

> It is required to now restore further confidence in State as service provider particularly in conflict hit areas including Balochistan, Sindh and FATA. The basic unit of the administration in Pakistan is the revenue district with a population, outside the metropolises, of between one and three million people approximately. It is the center where people live, own land and property, earn